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The Semiotics of Embodiment: Radical Orthodoxy and Jewish-Christian Relations

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One of the greatest thorns in the side of Jewish-Christian relations has been contending with and overcoming Christianity's charge that Jews and Judaism remain bound by the flesh in contrast to Christians who, through Christ's resurrection, are elevated into the life of the spirit. This charge, of course, goes all the way back to Paul.^[^1] In recent years, Christian theologians have begun reconsidering the doctrine of the incarnation. This issue has captured the attention of two schools of Christian theology; narrative theology and radical orthodoxy. Currently however, only narrative theologians have analyzed how a reevaluation of the body of Christ can advance Jewish-Christian relations. In this paper, I will argue that despite its best intentions, this narrative approach remains supercessionistic. Conversely, despite its failure to attend to the implications of its incarnational theology for Jewish-Christian relations, radical orthodoxy's appreciation of the semiotic character of Jesus' corporeality better links Jesus to the rabbinic tradition's semiotic practices and thereby opens up possibilities for Jews and Christians to study sacred texts together. In what follows I will compare radical orthodoxy's incarnational theology with a portrait of Jewish semiotic life in order to highlight the eucharistic character of rabbinic hermeneutics and the rabbinic character of Christian hermeneutics. Furthermore I will discuss the role of desire within their parallel scriptural practices and articulate how these practices can provide a basis for an ethical and just society.

Narrative Theology and the Eucharist

Radical Orthodoxy and the body of Jesus

Re-viewing Desire

The Donating Community

Jesus' Semiotic Body and Rabbinic Hermeneutics

The Torah and the Nearness of the Divine Word

Rabbi Joshua b. Levi said: When Moses ascended on high, the ministering angels spoke before the Holy One, blessed be He, 'Sovereign of the universe! What business has one born of woman among us?' He answered them, 'He has come to receive the Torah.' They said to Him, 'That secret treasure . . . Thou desirest to give to flesh and blood! . . . The Holy One, blessed be He, said to Moses, 'Return them an answer.' . . . He [then] spoke before Him, 'Sovereign of the universe! The Torah which Thou givest me, what is written therein? I am the Lord thy God, who brought thee out of the land of Egypt (Exod. 20:2). 'Said he to them [the angels], 'Did you go down to Egypt? Were you enslaved to Pharaoh?, etc. Again what is written therein? Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy (Exod. 20:8). Do you then perform work that you need to rest?, etc. Again, what is written therein? Honor thy father and thy mother (Exod. 20:12). Do you have any fathers and mothers? . . . Straight away they conceded to Him.' ¹

¹Of course, the New Testament gospel accounts are the church's earliest body of confessional discourse. Consequently, Ward maintains that the New Testament is nothing other than the witness to Jesus' own semiotic performance, as "reperformed and ventriloquized by the community he brought to birth."^[^19] Like Jesus' own semiotic performance, the

Responding to the story Joseph Soloveitchik says, "God does not wish to hand over His Torah to the ministering angels. . . he handed over His Torah to Moses, who brought it down to the earth and caused it to dwell among human beings . . ." ² Elliot Wolfson has done much to highlight the incarnational themes within the mystical tradition and speaks of "the textualization of God ' that is, God's becoming concretely manifest in the form of the Torah." ^[^25]

By going back to the Hebrew text from the translations . . . [one discovers] the strange or mysterious ambiguity or polysemy authorized by the Hebrew syntax . . . words coexist rather than immediately being coordinated or subordinated with and to one another . . . returning to the Hebrew text . . . makes it more difficult than one thinks to decide on the ultimate intention of a verse . . . there is no one verse, not one word of the Old Testament - . . . read by way of revelation that does not half-open to an entire world . . . ³

Moreover, this plurivocal character acts as an invitation, a mandate, if you will for readers to participate in the creativity of the Torah. The Torah's plurivocality translates into its interpretability and as Levinas says, "this invitation to seek and decipher, to Midrash, already constitutes the reader's participation in the Revelation, in Scripture. The reader, in his own fashion, is a scribe." ⁴ Rabbinic hermeneutics is eucharistic and through it "we get a first indication of what we might call the 'status' of the Revelation: its coming from elsewhere, from outside, and simultaneously dwelling in the person who receives it." ⁵

The Semiotics of Torah and Desire

Scriptural Reasoning therefore emerges out of the dialectic of modernity as the expression of a new, creative activity. . . . One may begin to see a coherence among the use of the following chain of tropes: a world to come, which is the product of resurrection; the Oral Torah, in which the written Torah lives its resurrected life; recreation, which is the way in which this second life is created; and, finally the "revealing of the divine

Gospel accounts invite readers into the economy of divine poesis that they have witnessed. Jesus' semiotic corporeality has initiated a community of messengers who receive and pass on the divine Word as it is re-created in the material world. A new collectivity, Ward says, "is born within and borne across the distensive absence." ^[^20]

²Ward's re-vision of the Christian doctrines of the incarnation, passion and resurrection are a product therefore, of a new Christian scriptural hermeneutic. In stark contrast to either allegorical or narrative hermeneutical approaches, Ward reads the New Testament as a semiotic performance of giving and receiving of signs that invites audience participation. Ward's kerygmatic message is not a proposition or a story about who Christ is, but a practice of living within God's created order. Ward's New Testament is not, as narrative theologians would think, an invitation into a closed narrative world, but rather, a call to go out into the world and participate in the process of creating and re-creating the world we have already been given through God's creative Word.

³The notion that the Torah is the place where God descends and draws near to the Jews occurs frequently within rabbinic and Jewish mystical writing. A famous rabbinic story offers a good example.

⁴By describing God's descent and nearness in Torah, Jews, like Ward, do not mean to suggest a vulgar theological positivism that elevates the material to identity with the divine. To speak of God's dwelling with Torah is not to speak about what the Torah is but rather what the Torah does, for God dwells in Torah through God's Word. But the divine Word creates and Torah becomes the stage of this creative activity. The rabbis linked Torah with God's *act* of creation. According to the Mishnah, Rabbi Akiba once said, "Beloved are Israel for unto them was given the instrument by which the world was created . . ." ^[^26] God, the Mishnah tells us, "looked in the Torah and created the world ." ^[^27] This does not mean that the rabbis envisioned the Torah along the lines of Platonic logos. Rather, when they spoke of God's creation through Torah they meant in fact, "not a concept but the concrete Torah with its precepts and statutes, which are inscribed in letters. Out of those letters . . . are the utterances with which the Almighty created the world." ^[^28]

⁵A third feature of rabbinic hermeneutics is the notion that, as God's act of creation, Torah meaning is never fixed but always subject to further development. Emanuel Levinas makes this point when he says,

presence,” which – to be distinguished from some aboriginal divine voice ‘ God speaks again and there is new life. . . . By listening to the voice of our Creator speaking through the words of scripture we have received through the past traditions that have interpreted them, through the sufferings that have engendered the end of modernity, and through finally the hope that must move us if we are at all to move.⁶

Semiotics of Embodiment and Jewish-Christian Relations

Notes

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[^r1] Paul frequently associates Jewish law with a life of the flesh in contrast to the life of faith and the Spirit. See Paul’s letter to Galatians, “Did you receive the Spirit by doing the works of the law or by believing what you heard? Are you so foolish? Having started with the Spirit, are you now ending with the flesh? . . . (Galatians 3:3-4).

[^r2] Scott Bader Saye, *Church and Israel After Christendom* (Westview, 1999), p. 142.

[^r3] Graham Ward, “The Displaced Body of Jesus Christ,” in *Radical Orthodoxy: A New Theology*, ed. John Milbank, Catherine Pickstock and Graham Ward (Routledge, 1999).

[^r4] Ibid., p. 165.

[^r5] Ibid., p.164

[^r6] Ibid., p.167.

[^r7] Robert Gibbs frequently employs this term when describing the practical events that take place in written and oral discourse. See Robert Gibbs, *Why Ethics: Signs of Responsibilities* (Princeton University Press, 2000).

[^r8] “Displaced Body,” p. 167.

⁶However, the strength of Ward’s semiotics is its appreciation of how the logic of semiotic displacement presupposes the reception of a gift. That is, neither eucharistic participation in the body of Christ nor, rabbinic exegesis mandate a denial of human desire. Rather, both re-situate desire within the context of divine plenitude and creative gift. If Jewish and Christian hermeneutical practice de-stabilize certainty in view of the promise of future interpretations, this suggests that these exegetical practices afford participants opportunities to balance their own desires with their responsibility to the future of the created Word. Still, if this were all, then Christian and Jewish exegetical practices might offer pragmatic bases for ethical life but would leave little room for meeting the interests or desires of the participants themselves. Participants would always, it would appear, forego their own desires for the sake of the future life of the created order. Only a utopian society could survive on such a program. Real societies must constantly balance between concern for the other and concern for oneself, between, in other words, ethics and justice. Fortunately, neither Ward’s theology nor much of contemporary Jewish thought are guilty of charges of utopianism.[^37]

[^r9] Ibid., p. 170.

[^r10] Ibid., 172.

[^r11] Ibid., p. 173.

[^r12] Ibid., p. 166.

[^r13] Ibid.

[^r14] Ibid., p. 167.

[^r15] Ibid.

[^r16] Ibid., p. 169.

[^r17] Ibid., p. 174.

[^r18] Ibid.

[^r19] Ibid., 163.

[^r20] Ibid., p. 175.

[^r21] Susan Handelman is perhaps, best known for this charge. See her, *Slayers of Moses, The Emergence of Rabbinic Interpretation in Modern Literary Theory* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1982).

[^r22] See my "Exegesis, Redemption and the Maculate Torah," in *Textual Reasonings*, ed. Peter Ochs and Nancy Levene (SCM Press, 2002) and my "Re-Admitting Philosophy into Contemporary Jewish Thought: An Encounter between Jewish Feminism and Exegetical Jewish Thought," in *On Being Human: Women in Jewish Philosophy*, ed. Hava Tirosh Samuelson (Indiana University Press, forthcoming).

[^r23] *Shabbat* 88b-89a.

[^r24] Joseph Soloveitchik, *Halakhic Man* (The Jewish Publication Society of America, 1983), p. 33.

[^r25] Elliot Wolfson, "Listening to Speak: A Response to Dialogues in Postmodern Jewish Philosophy," in Stephen Kepnes, Peter Ochs and Robert Gibbs, ed. *Reasoning After Revelation: Dialogues in Postmodern Jewish Philosophy* (Westview Press, 1998), p. 99.

[^r26] M. 'Avot iii, 14.

[^r27] Gen. Rabba i, 1.

[^r28] Ephraim Urbach, *The Sages* (Harvard University Press, 1979).

[^r29] Emanuel Levinas, "Revelation in the Jewish Tradition," in *Contemporary Jewish Theology: A Reader*, ed. Elliot N. Dorff and Louis E. Newman (Oxford University Press, 1999), 166.

[^r30] Ibid., 167.

[^r31] Ibid.

[^r32] See my "Re-Admitting Philosophy into Contemporary Jewish Thought: An Encounter between Jewish Feminism and Exegetical Jewish Thought," in *On Being Human: Women in Jewish Philosophy*, ed. Hava Tirosh Samuelson (Indiana University Press, forthcoming).

[^r33] Randi Rashkover, "Exegesis, Redemption and the Maculate Torah."

[^r34] In my dissertation, "Rosenzweig, Barth and the Theology of Election," (University of Virginia, 2000) I discuss the ramifications of Ward's neglect of a doctrine of command and election in the context of my own effort to assess the theological significance of divine command in Jewish and Christian covenantal life.

[^r35] Robert Gibbs, "Why Textual Reasoning?," *The Journal of Textual Reasoning: Rereading Judaism After Modernity*, volume 1.1., Spring 2002.

[^r36] See David Weiss Halivni, *Revelation Restored: Divine Writ and Critical Responses* (Westview Press, 1997).

[^r37] Gillian Rose often launched this critique of contemporary Jewish thought. See Gillian Rose, *The Broken Middle: Out of Our Ancient Society*, (Blackwell, 1992). Nonetheless, Rose could not consider a number of thinkers whose work, written after her death, focuses on the relationship

between desire and ethics e.g., David Novak, Miriam Peskowitz, Rachel Adler, et. al.

[^r38] Peter Ochs, "Rules of Scriptural Reasoning," *National Society of Scriptural Reasoning*, 1999.